

ENTREPRENEURIAL PULSE



E-club APIIT

apiit_eclub



SANDBOX OPENING



The opening ceremony and workshop session of the signature project of the E-Club, Sandbox InterSchool Business Pitching, took place on the 10th of September 2024 at the auditorium, City

Campus premises. Marking the official launch of the competition, the event commenced at 8.30AM, hosted by Methuli Perera where she took the participating schools through the structure of the competition, prizes, rules and regulations, the theme and the timeline. Participating schools included DS Senanayake College, St Bridget's Convent, Thurstan College, Bandranayake Central College Gampaha, St Nicholas International School and Gateway College Colombo.



The workshop session commenced at 9.15AM, conducted by Sasnaka Sansada, a government registered charitable organization aimed at brining welfare. The session was conducted by Ms Chamodi Swarnasinghe where she took the school teams along the process of constructing a viable business plan with the students being provided a specific template by the Sasnaka Sansada Foundation. Students were given the opportunity to ask questions and clarify their doubts about making a business plan and putting their business idea into words before the session wrapped up at 11AM for a break where a light refreshment was offered to participants.



By focusing on these areas, young graduates can shape their personal and professional journeys to reflect both who they are and who they aspire to become. Unleash Your Best U provided a platform for students to rethink their approach to career growth and self-presentation. The lessons imparted by Mr. Akbar will undoubtedly resonate with attendees as they step into the world of work, equipped with the skills and mindset necessary to succeed in today's dynamic business environment.



-ationery packs to the students of the school, calling in donations from the staff of Colombo campus as well. Following the conclusion of the 1st phase of the project, the 2nd phase saw the Colombo team travelling to Kandy via train on an exciting excursion. Participated by seven club EXCO members, four volunteers and three lecturers, the 2nd phase of the project took place on the 04th of September. Rendezvousing with the Kandy Eclub Team, the two teams then travelled to the school from the Kandy Railway Station to donate the books and stationery packs and to engage in a day of fun activities and enjoyment with the school students.



The school students engaged in a drawing sessions dubbed "draw your dreams" followed by snacks and more fun activities like musical chairs and dancing which the kids enjoyed. The project's aim did not only revolve around building a library but also on making an impact on the lives of these children who were confined to the walls of the school. With immense gratitude the Entrepreneurship Club of Kandy, the project was successfully concluded with dreams achieved, impact created and memories made.



SHARE THE STORY



Project Share the Story successfully concluded on the 04th of September 2024 with a resounding impact. The project which took place in two phases, was the first community project of the Entrepreneurship club of APIIT Colombo Campus. In collaboration with the Entrepreneurship Club of APIIT Kandy Campus, the aim of the project was to build a library for a rural school in Kandy. The first phase of the project saw both clubs running a book donation campaign in their respective campuses with the E-Club of APIIT Colombo collecting over a 100 Children's, Educational, Story and Non Fiction books in all three languages - English, Sinhala and Tamil over the course of the month of August. The E-Club of the Colombo Campus also pledged to provide st



The second phase culminated in a grand exhibition on the 6th of September 2024, hosted at APIIT's City Campus. From the 200 submissions, 60 exceptional photographs were shortlisted for display, transforming the space into a gallery of creativity and storytelling. The exhibition was honored by the presence of Chief Guest Mr. Avi Suriyabandara, a renowned photographer, whose presence added prestige to the event. Photopreneur stands as a testament to turning passions into business.



PHOTOPRENEUR



The Entrepreneurship Club of APIIT successfully concluded an exciting and visually captivating project dedicated to photography enthusiasts within the campus. Held under the banner of Photo-preneur, the competition aimed to provide a platform for students to showcase their talent across four diverse themes: nature, history, architecture, and society. The project unfolded in two vibrant phases. In the first phase, participants were invited to submit their best photographs reflecting these themes. The response was beyond expectations, with over 200 photographs submitted.

UPCOMING EVENTS

SANDBOX FINALE



Sandbox, the Interschool Business Pitching competition, the signature project of the E-Club will take place on the 09th of October 2024, at the Lotus Hall BMICH with twenty two participating teams representing various leading schools from the Colombo and Gampaha Districts including schools like Royal College, Ananda College, DS Senanayake College and Bandaranayake Central College Gampaha. The competition will revolve around five awards – the best business idea, most popular business idea, the

most sustainable product idea, 2nd place and 3rd place. All participants will receive a certificate of participation for the competition with an esteemed panel of judges taking centerstage to judge the competition. Under the theme of sustainability and conserving resources for the future, this competition is surely not one to miss. Stay tuned for more exciting updates and watch as the competition unfolds to a grand debacle.



STUDENT ENTREPRENEUR SPOTLIGHT:

THATTURRSHA SURESHKUMAR

BUSINESS PROFILE:

Glow Bea, a small business offering stunning earrings and necklaces, is perfect for traditional wear. Our collection features vibrant, colourful jewellery pieces imported from India, designed to add elegance to any outfit. At Glow Bea, we provide affordable, high-quality jewellery that allows you to express your style effortlessly.

1. What sparked your entrepreneurial spirit? How did you come up with your business idea?

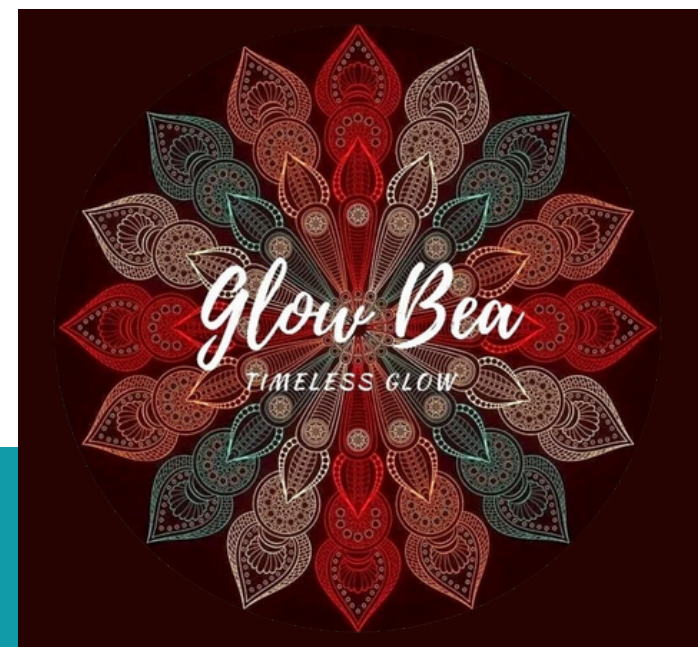
With plenty of free time outside of college and studies, I wanted to make the most of it by pursuing something productive. Having saved money from previous jobs, I decided to invest it in something I truly love: traditional earrings. As someone who enjoys collecting them, I thought, why not turn this passion into a business?

2. What have been the biggest challenges you've faced so far? What have you learned the most from these experiences?

A challenge I faced was with high-demand products. Sometimes, certain items would sell out quickly when first introduced, creating a lot of excitement. However, when I restocked them in larger quantities, the demand often dropped, leading to slow-moving inventory or unsold stock. I've learned that it's better to either offer products in limited quantities or carefully assess demand before restocking.

3. Why do you prefer running your own venture?

I prefer running my own venture because it gives me the freedom to make my own decisions and bring my ideas to life. I enjoy the flexibility of being in control of my work, setting my own goals, and building something from the ground up. It's rewarding to see the direct impact of my efforts.



4. What resources have been most helpful to you as a student entrepreneur?

Social media platforms have been invaluable in reaching my target audience and promoting my products effectively. They provide a cost-efficient way to market and engage with customers directly. Editing apps have been crucial for creating visually appealing content, allowing me to showcase my products in the best light. These tools have significantly streamlined my workflow, making it easier to manage my business while studying.

5. How do you balance your studies with running your business? Do you have any time management tips for other student entrepreneurs?

Balancing studies with running a business can be quite challenging, particularly on dispatch days. To manage this, I've organized my schedule so that I handle order packaging and dispatching primarily on weekends and one selected weekday. This allows me to stay on top of both my academic responsibilities and business operations more efficiently.

6. How are you marketing your business and reaching your target audience? What strategies have been most effective?

I primarily use social media advertisements to reach my audience, which has been highly effective. Additionally, I run occasional promotions, especially during festival weeks, to boost sales. One of the most successful strategies has been showcasing celebrities wearing similar jewellery to what I offer, which has drawn in a lot more customers.

7. Do you have any mentors or advisors who have supported your journey?

When I first decided to start my business, a close friend encouraged me to take the leap, even when others advised against the risk. I don't have a formal educational background in business, but my friend does, and he has been a guiding force throughout my journey. Whenever I had doubts or needed advice, he was there to provide support and valuable insights.

 @glowbea_lk

8. What advice would you give to other students seeking mentorship?

It's never a risk to give your ideas a chance; you should try as hard as you can to make them work. Embracing challenges can lead to unexpected opportunities for growth and success. Seek out mentors who share your passion or have experience in your field. Their insights can be invaluable, and building a relationship with them can provide ongoing support and guidance. Don't hesitate to ask questions and learn from their experiences; it can significantly accelerate your journey.

9. What are your top three pieces of advice for aspiring student entrepreneurs? What keeps you motivated and inspired?

Focus on launching with a manageable scope. This allows you to learn and adapt without overwhelming yourself. Once you gain confidence and understanding of your market, you can gradually expand your offerings. Stay organized and use tools and apps for time management, project tracking, and financial planning. Keeping everything organized helps you balance your studies and business more effectively, reducing stress. Connect with other entrepreneurs, attend workshops, and engage in online communities. Networking can provide valuable insights, support, and opportunities that can enhance your entrepreneurial journey. What keeps me motivated is the passion I have for my business and the excitement of seeing my ideas come to life. Each small success, whether it's a positive customer review or a new sale, fuels my drive to continue growing and improving.

10. Looking back, would you do anything differently? What have you enjoyed most about your entrepreneurial journey as a student?

Looking back, I wish I had been more organized with my finances and kept better track of all my transactions. This would have helped me avoid some challenges along the way. However, what I've enjoyed most about my entrepreneurial journey is the creative freedom it provides. I love expressing my passion for traditional earrings and connecting with customers who appreciate my work. The learning experiences, both the successes and the challenges have been incredibly fulfilling, and I value the personal growth that comes with being a student entrepreneur.

THE RISE AND CHALLENGES OF HOME-BASED BUSINESSES: NAVIGATING THE PATH TO SUCCESS

WRITTEN BY THATTURRSHA SURESHKUMAR



In recent years, the concept of home-based businesses has skyrocketed, with more people than ever seeking the flexibility and independence of working from home. Home-based enterprises are changing the face of entrepreneurship, whether they are selling handmade goods, e-commerce operations, or professional services. Yet, while these ventures offer undeniable appeal, particularly in terms of low start-up costs and flexibility, they come with a unique set of challenges that can make them difficult to sustain.

The Allure of Home-Based Businesses

There are various reasons why home-based enterprises are appealing. They make it possible for business owners to operate without having to worry about paying high overhead expenses, leasing office space, or commuting. The process of starting a business has been simplified with the help of digital technologies and online platforms, which allow business owners to reach a global clientele with little financial outlay. The freedom of working from home is one of the main draws. Owners of home-based businesses have more flexibility in scheduling, can accommodate duties to their families, and frequently have a better work-life balance. Particularly enticing to parents, carers, and people seeking part-time work to augment their income is this freedom.



The Challenges: More Than Meets the Eye

However, the freedom of running a business from home does not come without hurdles. Many entrepreneurs face obstacles that, if not managed carefully, can lead to burnout, financial losses, or even the closure of the business. The lack of a clear boundary between personal and professional spheres is a problem that many home-based business owners face. Close family members and domestic responsibilities might cause frequent disruptions that make it hard to concentrate on work or stay productive. Many people struggle to establish routines and a regulated work atmosphere. Despite lower overhead costs, home-based businesses are not immune to financial instability. New businesses often experience fluctuating income streams, especially during the early stages. Moreover, without careful budgeting, many entrepreneurs overspend on unnecessary tools, inventory, or marketing efforts, putting them in a precarious financial situation. Growing beyond a one-person operation frequently demands additional resources, investment, and possibly moving out of the home setting.



While the digital world offers endless opportunities, scaling a home-based business has its own set of limitations. Physical space constraints may hinder expansion and the lack of a professional shop front can create challenges in building credibility.

Potential Financial Losses

For every other company, there is always a chance of financial loss, and home-based businesses are no exception. Typical causes of loss include:

- Unpredictable Cash Flow:** It may be challenging to budget for operating expenses and cover personal expenditures when income is irregular.
- Overinvestment in Inventory:** A lot of proprietors of homebased businesses overestimate customer demand, which results in unsold inventory and locked up funds.
- Underfunding Marketing Efforts:** While some companies overspend on marketing, others underfund it, which hinders their ability to attract new clients and expand their clientele.

Strategies for Success

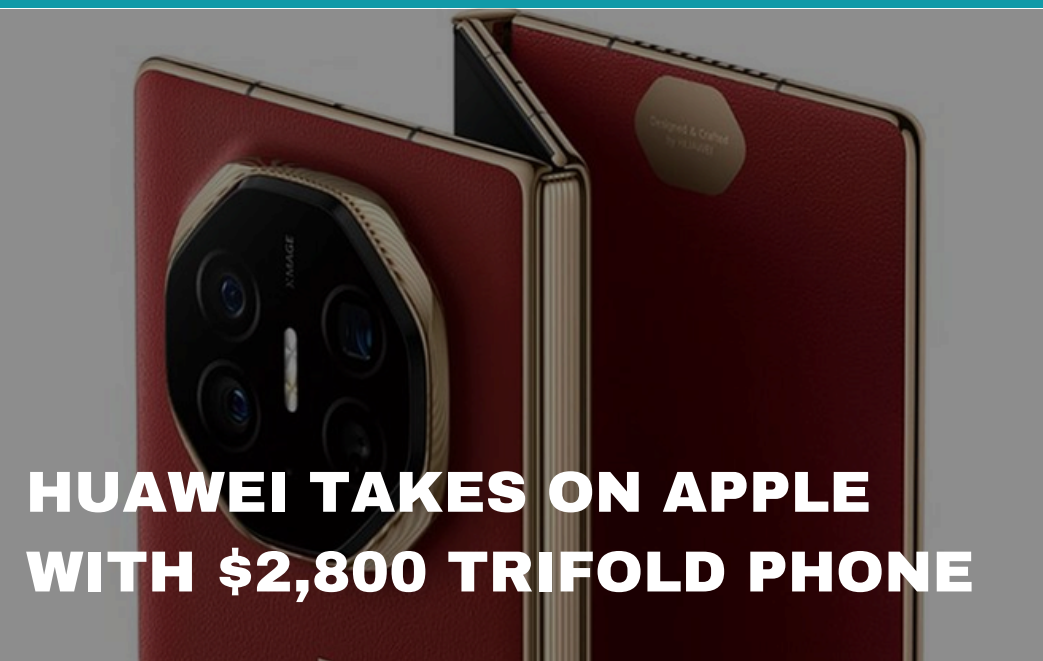
Despite the challenges, there are actionable strategies that home-based business owners can use to minimize risks and increase their chances of long-term success. A solid business plan is the cornerstone of any successful venture. Clearly outline your objectives, target audience, financial projections, and marketing strategy. This plan will act as a roadmap, helping you stay focused and make informed decisions. Start Small and Scale Gradually. Test the waters before committing significant resources. Starting small allows you to gauge market demand, identify challenges, and learn from mistakes without incurring heavy losses. As your business grows, gradually scale operations based on actual demand and resources. Leverage Digital Tools. Take advantage of modern technology to automate routine tasks and streamline operations. Project management software, e-commerce platforms, and social media tools can help you manage tasks more efficiently, freeing up time to focus on growth. Outsource When Necessary. Don't hesitate to outsource certain tasks, such as bookkeeping, customer service, or marketing, to professionals. This will allow you to concentrate on your core competencies while ensuring that other areas of your business are in capable hands. Build an Emergency Fund. An emergency fund acts as a financial buffer during slower periods or unexpected expenses.

Aim to save enough to cover at least three to six months of operational costs, so you're not left scrambling during periods of low revenue.

Customer Retention Over Acquisition, While acquiring new customers is vital, retaining existing ones is often more cost-effective. Focus on providing exceptional service, personalized experiences, and loyalty programs to ensure that customers return and refer others.

Home-based businesses offer flexibility, lower startup costs, and personal freedom, making them an attractive option for aspiring entrepreneurs. However, they come with challenges such as balancing work-life boundaries, financial instability, and scaling limitations. With careful planning, disciplined time management, and strategic investments in digital tools and marketing, home-based businesses can thrive and minimize losses, paving the way for long-term success.

BUSINESS UPDATES



**HUAWEI TAKES ON APPLE
WITH \$2,800 TRIFOLD PHONE**



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WITH \$2,800 TRIFOLD PHONE**



**BLACKSTONE CONSIDERS
SALE OF MAJORITY STAKE
IN VFS GLOBAL, VALUING
FIRM AT \$7 BILLION**



**BLACKSTONE DEAL UNLOCKS
\$670 MILLION FORTUNE FOR
AIRTRUNK'S SELF-MADE
FOUNDER**

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THE RISE OF TOMORROW'S
ENTREPRENEURS!**

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AND LECTURERS!**

